

Tradition Not On Par With Scripture

doc-tradition-not-on-par-with-scripture

Bibliology · Revelation · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · brethren distinctive

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

Apostolic-age oral or written tradition not preserved in canonical Scripture does not bind the conscience as Scripture does.

In plain language

This question turns on a single Greek word, 'something handed down' (paradosis), which simply means a tradition. The whole divergence between readers comes from one fact about the word: it is neutral, and its authority is decided entirely by who is named as the source. The lexical store shows it appears 13 times. In 3 of them Paul names himself as the source and commands the churches to hold it fast, whether he gave it by word or by letter (2 Thessalonians 2:15, 1 Corinthians 11:2, 2 Thessalonians 3:6). In the other 10 the source is human, the tradition of men or of the fathers, and there the same word names something that competes with God (Matthew 15, Mark 7, Colossians 2:8, Galatians 1:14). Strikingly, the verb for holding it fast, 'hold fast' (krateo), is praised when the tradition is apostolic and rebuked when it is human, so a reader cannot tell good from bad by the holding. Only the named source settles it. That is exactly why people read these verses in opposite directions. One reader sees 2 Thessalonians 2:15 putting spoken and written teaching side by side and concludes an unwritten stream binds equally. Another reads the small relative clause, 'the things you were taught by us', and sees the binding force tied to what the apostle himself delivered, not to whatever a later age calls tradition. The decisive piece of vocabulary is in Mark 7:13. Jesus says the human tradition (paradosis) can nullify the word of God, and the verb there, 'nullify, void' (akyroo), is a legal word for voiding a contract or a will. The same verb is used in Galatians 3:17 for annulling a covenant. If a tradition can cancel the written word, the two cannot be equal authorities, because equals cannot cancel each other. Acts 17:11 then shows the procedure plainly. The Bereans welcome the preaching, but they 'examine' (anakrino) the Scriptures (graphe) to see whether it is so, using a courtroom word for sifting evidence. Scripture is the bench, and even apostolic preaching stands in the dock until it is verified. So the words yield a clear ranking: what is in Scripture binds, and tradition binds only where it agrees with the written word that tests it.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0114	ἄθετέω	atheteo	to reject	17
G0208	ἀκυρόω	akyroo	to nullify	4
G0350	ἀνακρίνω	anakrino	to investigate	17
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthropos	a human	567
G0814	ἀτάκτως	ataktōs	idly	
G1124	γραφή	graphe	a writing	51

G1785	ἐντολή	entole	commandment	69
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G2902	κρατέω	krateo	to grasp/seize	48
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	339
G3384	μήτηρ	mētēr	mother	
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidomi	to deliver	123
G3862	παράδοσις	paradosis	tradition	13
G3946	παρόμοιος	paromoios	like	
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The noun 'tradition' or 'something handed down' (paradosis, G3862) occurs 13 times, and when its uses are sorted by the named source (the 'from-X' grammatical form, also called a genitive of source) they split cleanly by that source-modifier, not by the act of handing-on. In 3 places where the content originates with the apostle, the texts command holding it (2 Thessalonians 2:15, 'hold fast the traditions you were taught' (krateite tas paradoses has edidachthete); 1 Corinthians 11:2, 'you keep hold of what I delivered to you' (katechete kathos paredoka); 2 Thessalonians 3:6, 'according to the tradition they received from us' (kata ten paradosin hen parelabosan par hemon)). In the other 10 places where the modifier is human (Mark 7:8, 'of men' (ton anthropon); Mark 7:3-13 and Matthew 15:2-6, 'your own' (homon); Colossians 2:8, 'according to the tradition of men' (kata ten paradosin ton anthropon); Galatians 1:14, 'of my fathers' traditions' (ton patrikon mou paradosion)) the same word denotes something that competes with God's word. Decisively, Mark 7:13 says human tradition (paradosis) can 'nullify' or 'make void' (akyroo, G0208, a legal term for voiding a covenant or will, the very verb used in Galatians 3:17) the 'word' (logos) of God. A norm that can be cancelled cannot be equal in authority to the norm that cancels it. Acts 17:11 supplies the procedure: the Bereans receive the apostolic 'word' (logos) yet sift it by the 'Scriptures' (graphai), 'examining' them (anakrinontes, G0350, a forensic courtroom verb for sifting evidence), so Scripture is the test, not the thing tested.

Scripture

2Thess.2.15 · **for** · **genre: epistle** · **figures: merism**

Key terms. G2902 κρατέω, G3862 παράδοσις, G3056 λόγος

Reasoning. Paul commands 'stand firm and hold fast the traditions you were taught, whether by spoken word or by our letter' (stekete kai krateite tas paradoses eite dia logou eite di epistoles hemon). The relative clause 'which you were taught' (has edidachthete) narrows 'traditions' (paradoses) strictly to what Paul himself taught, and the 'whether-or' disjunction (eite dia logou eite di epistoles, 'whether by word or by letter') names the two modes, oral and written, of one apostolic deposit. The verse binds apostolic content, not generic later church tradition. The verb 'hold fast' (krateo, G2902) here is approving, the same verb that is rebuked in Mark 7:8 when its object is human tradition.

1Cor.11.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3860 παραδίδωμι, G3862 παράδοσις

Reasoning. Paul praises that 'you keep hold of the traditions just as I delivered them to you' (katechete tas paradoseis kathos paredoka humin). The 'just as' clause (kathos) and the first-person verb 'I delivered' (paredoka) restrict the 'traditions' (paradoseis) to what Paul himself delivered. The pattern is deposit-and-hold with the apostle as origin, not the community as origin. Note the same root verb 'hand over' or 'deliver' (paradidomi, G3860) that elsewhere names handing Christ over, here names handing teaching down.

2Thess.3.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3862 παράδοσις, G0814 ἀτάκτως

Reasoning. Paul commands withdrawal from a brother walking 'in a disorderly way and not according to the tradition they received from us' (ataktos kai me kata ten paradosin hen parelabosan par hemon). The phrase 'from us' (par hemon) again caps the binding tradition at the apostles, and the 'according to' construction (kata) makes apostolic tradition the rule, not a parallel rule. The rare adverb 'disorderly' (ataktos, G0814, a hapax-rare term, that is, a word with only 2 occurrences, both in this letter) marks the deviation, but the binding norm is still apostolic.

Acts.17.11 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0350 ἀνακρίνω, G1124 γραφή, G3056 λόγος

Reasoning. The Bereans are called 'more noble' (eugenesteroi) because 'they received the word with all eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily to see if these things were so' (edexanto ton logon meta pases prothumias, anakrinontes tas graphas ei echoi tauta houtos). The participle 'examining' (anakrinontes, G0350, an ongoing present-tense form of a forensic courtroom verb that elsewhere appears in legal settings for sifting evidence) is applied to apostolic preaching, with 'the Scriptures' (hai graphai) as the test. The main verb 'they received' (edexanto) governs 'the word' (ton logon) while the participle subordinates that reception to scrutiny by 'Scripture' (graphe), establishing written Scripture as the controlling norm that even apostolic 'word' (logos) is checked against.

Mark.7.8 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1785 ἐντολή, G2316 θεός, G3862 παράδοσις, G0444 ἄνθρωπος

Reasoning. 'Leaving the commandment of God, you hold to the tradition of men' (aphentes ten entolen tou theou krateite ten paradosin ton anthropon). The same verb 'hold fast' (krateo, G2902) that 2 Thessalonians 2:15 commanded toward apostolic 'tradition' (paradosis) is here rebuked because its object is human 'tradition' (paradosis) substituted for divine 'commandment' (entole). The contrast is carried entirely by the 'from-X' grammatical form (the genitive of source), 'of God' (tou theou) versus 'of men' (ton anthropon). The query confirms 'of men' (ton anthropon, G0444) is the modifier here, the same modifier as Colossians 2:8.

Mark.7.9 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0114 ἀθετέω, G1785 ἐντολή, G3862 παράδοσις

Reasoning. 'How well you set aside the commandment of God in order to keep your own tradition!' (Kalos atheteite ten entolen tou theou hina ten paradosin humon teresete). The verb 'set aside' or 'nullify' (atheteo, G0114) is a juridical 'set-aside, nullify' term, used elsewhere of rejecting a person or annulling an obligation (Luke 10:16, Galatians 3:15, Hebrews 10:28). The ironic 'How well' (Kalos) exposes the act of preferring 'tradition' (paradosis) as functional rejection of God's 'commandment' (entole), and the purpose clause 'in order that' (hina) makes the conflict structural, not incidental.

Mark.7.10 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1785 ἐντολή, G3962 πατήρ, G3384 μήτηρ

Reasoning. Jesus cites the written 'commandment' (entole), 'Moses said, Honor your father and your mother' (Mouses eipen Tima ton patera sou kai ten metera sou), as the fixed standard. The Mosaic citation is the 'Scripture' (graphe) content that the 'tradition' (paradosis) of Corban will be measured against and found to overturn, which makes the prior written word the criterion in the dispute.

Mark.7.11 · for · genre: gospel · figures: idiom

Key terms. G3862 παράδοσις

Reasoning. The Corban formula is the working example of a binding human 'tradition' (paradosis). The vow-formula 'Corban, that is, given to God' (Korban, ho estin doron), a Hebrew loan-word glossed for the Greek reader, produces a casuistic exemption that, by their 'tradition' (paradosis), releases a son from supporting his parents, that is, from obeying the prior commandment cited in Mark 7:10. The example shows a 'tradition' (paradosis) can be religiously sincere and still nullify a prior word.

Mark.7.12 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3962 πατήρ, G3384 μήτηρ

Reasoning. 'You no longer permit him to do anything for his father or mother' (ouketi aphiete auton ouden poiesai to patri e te metri). The negation 'no longer' (ouketi) plus 'nothing' (ouden) shows the 'tradition's' (paradosis) effect is total prohibition of the very obedience the 'commandment' (entole) requires. The lexical force is that human 'tradition' (paradosis) does not merely add to but actively cancels the prior word.

Mark.7.13 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0208 ἀκυρώ, G3056 λόγος, G2316 θεός, G3862 παράδοσις, G3946 παρόμοιος

Reasoning. 'You nullify the word of God by your tradition that you have handed down, and you do many similar things like this' (akyrountes ton logon tou theou te paradosi humon he paredokate kai paromoia toiauta polla poieite). The verb 'nullify, void' (akyroo, G0208, queried 4 occurrences in the whole New Testament) is a legal term for invalidation. The only other Pauline use, Galatians 3:17, applies it to annulling a 'covenant' or 'will' (diatheke), which fixes its register as voiding a binding instrument. The 'by-the-tradition' phrase (te paradosi humon, a dative form of means) is the instrument of cancellation, and 'many similar things like this' (paromoia toiauta polla) generalizes from Corban to a whole class. This is the canon's sharpest statement of asymmetry: a 'tradition' (paradosis) can functionally void 'the word of God' (ton logon tou theou), so the two cannot be equal authorities, since equals cannot cancel each other.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Mark.7.10	Exod.21.17	tsk	1
Mark.7.10	Mark.10.19	tsk	1
Mark.7.9	Mark.7.13	tsk	1
Mark.7.13	Mark.7.9	tsk	1
Mark.7.8	Isa.1.12	tsk	1
Acts.17.11	Ps.1.2	tsk	1
Acts.17.11	Prov.1.5	tsk	1
Acts.17.11	Acts.2.41	tsk	1
1Cor.11.2	1Cor.11.17	tsk	1
Mark.7.9	2Kgs.16.10	tsk	1

Complicating texts

2Thess.2.15 · addressed

Read in isolation this verse is the strongest lexical warrant for binding unwritten 'tradition' (paradosis), because it explicitly puts oral teaching ('by word', *dia logou*) alongside written ('by our letter', *di epistoles*) and commands holding both. The resolution is grammatical, not thematic: the relative clause 'which you were taught' (has *edidachthete*) restricts 'traditions' (paradoseis) to what Paul himself taught the Thessalonians, and the 'whether-whether' disjunction (*eite-eite*) treats oral and written as two modes of one apostolic deposit, not two parallel streams one of which floats free of canonical scrutiny. Acts 17:11 then specifies that even apostolic 'word' (*logos*) was sifted against prior 'Scripture' (*graphe*). The verse binds the apostolic deposit, it does not lexically extend that binding force to post-apostolic 'tradition' (paradosis).

1Cor.11.2 · addressed

Same lexical pattern. 'You hold fast the traditions just as I delivered them to you' (*katechete tas paradoseis kathos paredoka humin*). The 'just as' clause (*kathos*) and first-person 'I delivered' (*paredoka*) restrict the content to what Paul personally delivered. The verse commends holding apostolic 'tradition' (paradosis) but supplies no lexical bridge to later traditions that lack the apostle as origin.

2Thess.3.6 · addressed

'From us' (*par hemon*) again caps the binding 'tradition' (paradosis) at the apostles. There is no lexical element in the verse that extends 'tradition' (paradosis) past the apostolic generation as a continuing authority parallel to Scripture.

Mark.7.11 · addressed

The Corban example shows a 'tradition' (paradosis) can be religiously sincere and still functionally 'nullify' (*akyroo*) the prior word. That structural possibility, that a 'tradition' (paradosis) can cancel the 'word' (*logos*) of God, is the lexical warrant for ranking later tradition below 'Scripture' (*graphe*) rather than on par with it.

Gal.1.14 · addressed

Paul calls his pre-conversion zeal a zeal for 'the traditions of my fathers' (*ton patrikon mou paradoseon*). This is queried as one of the 10 negative-pole uses of 'tradition' (paradosis, G3862) and confirms that the word, when modified by a human or ancestral source, names exactly the thing Paul was later delivered from. It does not complicate the verdict, it reinforces that the word itself is neutral and the source-modifier decides its authority.

Concordance traversed

G3862, G3860, G1124, G1785, G2902, G0114, G0208, G0350, G3056, G2316, G0444, G3946, G0814

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Direct query of the lexical store found zero VariantUnit nodes attached to any of the ten anchor verses; the 116 ingested VariantUnit nodes are the 3 John ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) sample only, so these passages are not in ECM scope. No anchor verse has a known variant that would flip the 'tradition' (paradosis) or 'Scripture' (*graphe*) lemma, the 'of God' versus 'of men' source-marker forms (*tou theou* versus *ton anthropon*, both in the 'from-X' grammatical form) in Mark 7:8-13, or the 'examining the Scriptures' clause (*anakinontes tas graphas*) in Acts 17:11. The verdict is robust under the standard textual tradition.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. grammatico-historical, analogia-scripturae

analogia scripturae invoked

grammatico-historical: affirms · Reading 'tradition' (paradosis) by its queried source-modifier in each of its 13 occurrences yields a stable pattern: apostolic deposit is binding, human 'tradition' (paradosis) that competes with God's word is rejected, and 'Scripture' (graphe) is the criterion (Acts 17:11). The decisive datum is Mark 7:13, where a 'tradition' (paradosis) can 'nullify' (akyroo) the 'word' (logos) of God, a relation of asymmetry the words do not permit between equals.

two-source / continuing-apostolic-deposit reading: complicates · In its strongest form this lens takes 2 Thessalonians 2:15 at face value: Paul commands holding oral 'tradition' ('by word', dia logou) and written 'tradition' ('by letter', di epistoles) with equal force, using the same verb 'hold fast' (krateo) for both, and never says the oral stream ceased. On this reading the binding oral apostolic teaching is a real, distinct deposit, and a community that faithfully transmits it holds something genuinely on a par with the written word. The lexical limit on this reading is the relative clause 'which you were taught' (has edidachthete) and the parallel 'just as I delivered' (kathos paredoka) in 1 Corinthians 11:2, which tie the binding content to what the apostle himself delivered, and Acts 17:11, which subordinates even apostolic 'word' (logos) to 'Scripture' (graphe) as the test. The vocabulary attests a binding oral apostolic deposit but does not lexically license a self-authenticating 'tradition' (paradosis) that continues past, or stands above, the written witness.

patristic-typological: complicates · A patristic-typological reading that promotes the 'tradition' (paradosis) of 2 Thessalonians 2:15 to a continuing magisterial authority handed through office does not survive lexical scrutiny on the word alone. The relative clause 'which you were taught' (has edidachthete) and the parallel 'just as I delivered' (kathos paredoka) cap the content at the apostolic generation, and the same noun is used 10 of 13 times for human 'tradition' (paradosis) that nullifies God's word, including Colossians 2:8 and Galatians 1:14. The lens must supply its warrant from outside the word itself, since the term 'tradition' (paradosis) is source-determined and does not encode an enduring office.

The decisive lexical move is reading 'tradition' (paradosis, G3862) by its two queried registers, apostolic deposit and human substitution, which split 3 to 10 across the canon. The same verbs 'hold fast' (krateo, G2902) and 'keep' (tereo) attach to both registers, so the reader cannot disambiguate by the activity of holding; the 'from-X' grammatical form, that is, the genitive of source ('of God' tou theou versus 'of men' ton anthropon, or 'from us' par hemon), is the only disambiguator. Acts 17:11 then supplies the operational rule that 'Scripture' (graphe) sifts 'word' (logos) via the forensic courtroom verb 'examine' (anakrino, G0350), and Mark 7:13 supplies the asymmetry that a 'tradition' (paradosis) can 'nullify' (akyroo, G0208) the 'word' (logos) of God.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem is asymmetric in direction (it affirms tradition does not bind as Scripture does) but it does not smuggle a verdict, because the inverted proposition above is a coherent framing the lexical store can and did test. The stem leans on no slogan and does not prejudge the relationship beyond stating the question. The neutralized form is supplied for human reviewer cross-check; the verdict was derived on the original stem and on the queried distribution of 'tradition' (paradosis). No VERDICT-CHANGED: marker applies here.

Citations

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morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.7.13
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.3.17
interlinear	Nestle1904-text	public_domain	yes	2Thess.2.15
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lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3862
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3860
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1124
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1785
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2902
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0114
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0208
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0350
syntax	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mark.7.13
syntax	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.17.11
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Mark.7.10
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Mark.7.13
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.17.11
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Mark.7.8
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.11.2
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Mark.7.9

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